A FREE, PLAIN-SPOKEN GUIDE



Disability Benefits Made Simple

A Plain-Language Guide to SSDI, SSI, Appeals, Working, and Your Rights on the Job

SSDI vs. SSI • Applying • Appeals
Ticket to Work • ADA accommodations

D.A. Williams

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D.A. Williams

Published by Red Pills of Freedom

Free to share. Please pass it on to someone who needs it.

Dedicated to Mom, Janis Fredlund

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This book is for general education. It is not legal advice, and it does not replace advice from Social Security, a lawyer, or a benefits counselor about your own situation. Rules, dollar amounts, and phone numbers were checked against official sources listed in the Notes as of October 2026. **Program rules and amounts change, usually every January. Always verify current rules at ssa.gov.**

The short scenes and calculations marked "Example" in this book are made up to show how a rule works. They are not stories about real people, and your own numbers may be different.

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INTRODUCTION

You Don’t Have to Figure This Out Alone

If you are reading this, you may be dealing with a health problem that has made work hard or impossible. Maybe it’s you. Maybe it’s your spouse, your parent, your adult child, or a friend. Either way, you have probably already noticed that disability benefits come wrapped in a lot of confusing words: SSDI, SSI, SGA, DDS, ALJ, TWP, EPE.

This book takes those words apart, one at a time, in plain English.

Here is the first thing to know: Social Security runs two different disability programs, and they have different rules. The second thing to know is that a “no” doesn’t have to be the end of the story. You have the right to appeal, and there are strict deadlines for doing it. The third thing to know is that you can try working without automatically losing your benefits. There are special rules built for exactly that.

Social Security itself says disability is more common than most people think. It says studies show a 20-year-old

worker has a 1-in-4 chance of developing a disability before reaching full retirement age.[1]

IMPORTANT: Rules change. Verify at ssa.gov. The dollar amounts in this book are the official amounts for 2026, plus the 2027 amounts Social Security has already announced. These numbers change almost every year. Before you make a decision about money or work, check the current figures at **ssa.gov** or call Social Security at **1-800-772-1213** (TTY 1-800-325-0778).[1]

What’s inside

- **Chapters 1 to 3** explain the two programs, what “disabled” means to Social Security, and the current dollar amounts.
- **Chapters 4 to 7** walk you through applying, why claims get denied, how to appeal, and where to get help.
- **Chapters 8 to 10** explain how to try working without losing everything at once.
- **Chapter 11** covers your rights at work under the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA).
- **Chapter 12** covers reporting changes and avoiding scams.

- At the back you’ll find a **one-page checklist** you can print, a list of free help, and the sources for every fact in the book.

You don’t need to read it all at once. Start with the chapter that fits where you are today.

CHAPTER 1

Two Programs: SSDI and SSI

Social Security pays disability benefits through two programs: **Social Security Disability Insurance (SSDI)** and **Supplemental Security Income (SSI)**.[1] They sound alike, and both are run by Social Security, but they work very differently.

SSDI: based on your work record

SSDI is like an insurance policy you paid for through the Social Security taxes taken out of your paychecks. To qualify, you need two things:

1. A disability that meets Social Security's definition (more on that in Chapter 2), and
2. Enough work history.

Social Security says that, generally, you must have worked for at least 5 of the last 10 years to qualify, and that people under age 24 may not need to have worked as long.[2] The exact rule depends on your age when your disability started (see the table in Chapter 3).

Key facts about SSDI:

- **The amount is based on your past earnings.** Your monthly benefit depends on your average lifetime earnings covered by Social Security.[3] Social Security estimated that the average monthly benefit for all disabled workers was $1,630 in January 2026, after that year's cost-of-living increase.[4]
- **There is usually a five-month waiting period.** If you're approved, Social Security generally pays your first benefit for the sixth full month after the date it decides your disability began. There is no waiting period if your disability results from ALS (Lou Gehrig's disease) and you were approved on or after July 23, 2020.[3]
- **Medicare comes later.** Social Security automatically enrolls you in Medicare after you've received disability benefits for two years. People with ALS get Medicare sooner, and there is also no Medicare waiting period for people with End Stage Renal Disease (ESRD).[3,1]
- **Family members may qualify too.** Certain family members, such as a spouse caring for your young child, or your unmarried children under 18, may be able to get benefits on your record.[1]

SSI: based on financial need

SSI is not based on your work history. It is for people with very little income and very few resources (things you own) who are age 65 or older, blind, or have a qualifying disability.[10] It is paid from general tax money, not from the Social Security trust funds.[10]

Key facts about SSI:

- **There's a monthly maximum.** The basic federal SSI payment for 2026 is up to **$994 a month** for one person and **$1,491** for a couple. Many states add money on top.[4,10]
- **Income lowers the payment.** Social Security subtracts your "countable" income from the maximum. Not every dollar counts. For example, it doesn't count the first $20 of most monthly income, or the first $65 of your monthly earnings from work and half of the rest.[10]
- **There's a strict resource limit.** Your countable resources generally can't be worth more than **$2,000** for one person or **$3,000** for a couple.[9] Some things don't count, including the home you live in and usually one car.[10]
- **SSI usually comes with Medicaid help.** When you get SSI, you may also get Medicaid, which helps pay doctor and hospital bills.[10]

- **Where you live matters.** To get SSI you generally must live in one of the 50 states, the District of Columbia, or the Northern Mariana Islands.[10]

Can you get both?

Yes, some people can. Social Security says that if you have worked long enough, you may be able to get Social Security benefits while you also get SSI.[10] This often happens when someone's SSDI payment is small. Social Security also says that if you're eligible for other benefits, you must apply for them as part of getting SSI.[10]

SSDI and SSI side by side

	SSDI	SSI
Based on	Your work history	Financial need
Savings limit	None	$2,000 (single), $3,000 (couple)
Monthly amount	Based on your past earnings	Up to $994 (single) in 2026, minus countable income
Health coverage	Medicare after 2 years of benefits	Often Medicaid

Sources: see the Notes for Chapters 1 and 3.

What to do

1. **Check your work record.** Create or sign in to your personal *my Social Security* account at ssa.gov/myaccount. Social Security says you can sign in and

look under “More Benefits” to see if you’ve worked long enough to qualify for disability.[2]

2. **If you’re not sure which program fits, apply anyway.** Social Security will look at both. If you’re an adult applying for both, you may be able to apply online for both at the same time if you meet certain conditions.[10]

CHAPTER 2

What “Disabled” Means to Social Security

Social Security uses a very strict definition of disability. In its own words, it pays disability benefits “to people who can’t work because they have a medical condition that’s expected to last at least one year or result in death.” It adds: “While some programs give money to people with a partial or short-term disability, we do not.”[1]

That means a broken leg that will heal in four months usually won’t qualify, no matter how painful it is. It also means your doctor’s opinion matters but is not the final word. Social Security says plainly: “Your doctors don’t decide if you meet our definition of disability.”[1]

Who makes the decision

When you apply, Social Security first checks the non-medical rules, like whether you’ve worked long enough. Then it sends your case to a state agency called **Disability Determination Services (DDS)**. Doctors and disability specialists there ask your medical providers

about when your condition began, how it limits you, your test results, and your treatment.[1]

If they need more information, they may ask you to go to a special exam, called a **consultative examination**. Social Security pays for the exam and some related travel costs.[1]

The five questions

The state agency uses five questions, in order:[1]

1. **Are you working?** If you’re earning more than a set monthly amount (called “substantial gainful activity,” or SGA), you generally won’t qualify. For 2026, that amount is $1,690 a month, or $2,830 if you’re blind.[2]
2. **Is your condition “severe”?** It must significantly limit basic work activities, such as walking, sitting, lifting, standing, carrying, or remembering instructions, for at least 12 months.
3. **Is your condition on the list?** Social Security keeps a “listing of impairments,” conditions it considers severe enough to prevent work. If yours meets or equals a listing, you’re found disabled at this step.
4. **Can you do the work you did before?** If you can still do your past work, you won’t qualify.
5. **Can you do any other type of work?** Social Security looks at your age, education, past work, and skills to decide whether you could adjust to other work.

Notice that steps 4 and 5 are about *work*, not just about your diagnosis. Two people with the same condition can get different answers, because their ages, jobs, and limits are different. That’s why it matters so much to describe clearly what you *can’t* do on a bad day.

Faster decisions for the most serious conditions

Social Security has a program called **Compassionate Allowances**. It is a way to quickly identify conditions that, by definition, meet Social Security’s standards. These conditions mainly include certain cancers, adult brain disorders, and a number of rare disorders that affect children.[12] Social Security says it uses technology to identify these claims so it can decide them quickly.[12]

How long it takes

Social Security says processing an application for disability benefits takes, on average, six to eight months. It says it may be able to go faster if you give it the information it needs, such as the names and addresses of your doctors and clinics, your medicines, and your medical records.[1]

What to do

1. **Keep going to your doctors** and keep notes on how your condition affects daily life and work.

2. **Be specific.** “My back hurts” says less than “I can’t sit more than 20 minutes or lift a gallon of milk.”
3. **Go to any exam Social Security schedules.** If you truly can’t make it, call before the date (see Chapter 5).

CHAPTER 3

The Numbers for 2026 (and 2027)

These are the official amounts, straight from Social Security. In October 2026, Social Security announced a 3.6 percent cost-of-living adjustment (COLA) for 2027, and it has already published several 2027 amounts.[5] Both years are shown here so you'll know what's coming.

REMEMBER: These amounts change, usually every January. Verify current figures at ssa.gov before you make a decision.

Key disability amounts

Item	2026	2027
SGA (non-blind), per month	$1,690	$1,770
SGA (blind), per month	$2,830	$2,950
Trial Work Period month, earnings over	$1,210	$1,270
SSI federal maximum, individual	$994	$1,029
SSI federal maximum, couple	$1,491	$1,544

Item	2026	2027
SSI resource limit, individual	$2,000	—
SSI resource limit, couple	$3,000	—
SSI student earned income exclusion	$2,410/month, $9,730/year	—

Sources: 2026 figures from Social Security's 2026 COLA Fact Sheet; 2027 figures from Social Security's SGA, Trial Work Period, and SSI payment pages.[4,6,7,8] *A dash means Social Security had not published a 2027 figure on the pages checked; check ssa.gov.*

A few notes on these numbers:

- **SGA** is the monthly earnings level Social Security uses to decide whether you're working too much to be considered disabled. The higher blind amount does not apply to SSI.[6]
- **The Trial Work Period** applies only to SSDI, not SSI.[7] Chapter 8 explains it.
- **SSI maximums** are reduced by your countable income, and some states add a supplement.[8]
- **The 2027 SSI increase** shows up first in the SSI payment dated December 31, 2026, according to Social Security.[5]

The SSI earnings rule of thumb

Social Security's SSI eligibility page says SSI "is generally for individuals who don't earn more than $2,073 from

work each month," and that the limit is higher for couples and when parents apply for children.[9] That number is a rough ceiling, not your payment amount. Your actual SSI depends on all your income.

How much work you need for SSDI

For SSDI, Social Security uses two work tests: a "recent work" test and a "duration of work" test.[1] The recent work test, by age, generally looks like this:

If your disability began…	You generally need…
In or before the quarter you turn 24	1.5 years of work in the 3 years before
After 24 but before the quarter you turn 31	Work in half the time since age 21
At age 31 or later	5 years of work in the last 10 years

Source: Social Security, Disability Benefits (Publication No. 05-10029), July 2026.[1]

Social Security calls this "an estimate only" that "does not cover all situations."[1] Your *my Social Security* account can tell you where you stand.

CHAPTER 4

How to Apply, Step by Step

Applying takes time, but it is not as scary as it looks. Social Security says: “Do not delay applying for benefits because you do not have all the documents. We will help you get them.”[11]

Three ways to apply

- **Online** at ssa.gov/applyfordisability. You can stop, save, and come back to your application.[11]
- **By phone** at 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778), Monday through Friday, 8 a.m. to 7 p.m. Social Security will set up a phone or in-person appointment and send you a Disability Starter Kit to help you prepare.[1]
- **In person** at your local Social Security office. Call first to make an appointment.[11]

The online adult disability application is for people who are 18 or older, aren’t already getting benefits on their own record, can’t work because of a condition expected to last at least 12 months or result in death, and haven’t been denied disability benefits in the last 60 days.[11] If

you were denied recently, you probably need to appeal instead (Chapter 6).

Step 1: Gather your information

Social Security suggests having this information ready:[11]

- **About you:** your date and place of birth and Social Security number; information about your current and any former spouse; your minor children's names and dates of birth; and your bank routing and account numbers for direct deposit.
- **About your health:** names, addresses, phone numbers, patient ID numbers, and dates of treatment for all your doctors, hospitals, and clinics; your medicines and who prescribed them; and the medical tests you've had and who sent you for them. Also have the name of someone who knows about your condition and can help with your application.
- **About your work:** how much you earned last year and this year; your employers for this year and last year; a list of up to 5 jobs you had in the 5 years before you became unable to work; and information about any workers' compensation or similar benefits.

Step 2: Gather documents you already have

Social Security may ask for proof such as your birth certificate, proof of citizenship or lawful status, your W-2 forms or self-employment tax return for last year, and

medical records you already have.[11] It accepts photocopies of W-2s, tax returns, and medical documents, but must see the original of most other documents, like a birth certificate, and will return them.[11]

Two cautions from Social Security:[11]

- Don't write anything on original documents. If you mail them, put your Social Security number on a separate sheet of paper in the envelope.
- Don't mail foreign birth records or Department of Homeland Security documents. Bring them to an office instead, because they are hard or impossible to replace.

Step 3: Fill out the forms

Besides the application itself, you'll fill out a form about your medical condition and how it affects your ability to work (Form SSA-3368), and a form that lets your doctors and hospitals send your records to Social Security (Form SSA-827).[1]

Take your time on the description of your condition. Write about your worst days as well as your average days. Include things like how long you can sit, stand, or walk; whether you can lift things; whether you can concentrate, remember instructions, or be around other people; and side effects of your medicines.

Step 4: Keep copies and a log

Keep a copy of everything you send. Keep a simple notebook with the date, the person you spoke to, and what they said every time you talk to Social Security or DDS. If you move or change phone numbers, tell Social Security right away so you don't miss a letter.

Step 5: Watch your mail and answer quickly

Social Security will confirm your application, may contact you for more information, and will mail its decision.[11] DDS may send you questionnaires. Answer them on time.

What to do this week

1. Create your *my Social Security* account at ssa.gov/myaccount.
2. Print Social Security's adult disability checklist (linked from ssa.gov/applyfordisability).[11]
3. Make a list of every doctor, clinic, and hospital you've seen, with dates.
4. Start your application, even if you don't have everything yet.

CHAPTER 5

Why Claims Get Denied

Being turned down is discouraging, but it is not always the end. Understanding *why* claims are denied helps you avoid problems, or fix them on appeal.

Most denial reasons follow directly from the rules in Chapters 1 to 3. Here are the common ones, with what you can do about each.

1. Earning too much

If you're working and earning more than the SGA amount ($1,690 a month for non-blind people in 2026), you generally won't meet the definition of disability.[2,1]

What to do: Tell Social Security about any work, including the hours and pay. Ask about "impairment-related work expenses," which the SGA amount is figured net of.[6]

2. The condition isn't expected to last 12 months

Social Security does not pay for short-term disability.[1]

What to do: If your doctor expects your condition to last a year or more, make sure your medical records say so.

3. Not enough medical evidence

DDS decides based on the evidence it has. If your records are thin, out of date, or don't describe your limits, DDS may decide your condition isn't severe enough.[1]

What to do: List every provider, including therapists and clinics. Send records you already have. Ask your doctors to describe what you can and can't do, not just your diagnosis.

4. Social Security decides you can still work

At steps 4 and 5 of the process, DDS may decide that you can still do your old job, or that you could adjust to other work, given your age, education, and skills.[1]

What to do: Describe the real demands of your past jobs (how much lifting, standing, or concentration they took) and exactly why you can't do them now.

5. Missing a scheduled exam

If Social Security arranges a consultative examination and you fail or refuse to go without a good reason, it may find that you're not disabled. Its rules list examples of good reasons, such as being sick on the exam date, not getting timely notice, being given wrong information

about the exam, or a death or serious illness in your immediate family.[13]

What to do: Go to every exam. If you can't, call *before* the date. If you have a good reason, Social Security will schedule another exam.[13]

6. Not enough work credits (SSDI)

If you haven't worked enough recently, or long enough overall, you can't get SSDI, no matter how serious your condition is.[1]

What to do: Ask whether you might qualify for SSI instead, or for benefits on a parent's or spouse's record.[11]

7. Too much income or too many resources (SSI)

For SSI, having more than $2,000 in countable resources ($3,000 for a couple), or too much countable income, will make you ineligible.[9]

What to do: Learn which things don't count. The home you live in, usually one car, and certain burial funds are not counted.[10] An ABLE account (Chapter 10) may help some people save without losing SSI.

8. Missing a deadline or not responding

If you don't answer forms or requests, Social Security may have to decide without the information it asked for.

What to do: Open every letter right away. Write the deadline on your calendar.

CHAPTER 6

Appealing a Denial: The Four Levels

If you disagree with Social Security's decision, you have the right to appeal. Social Security describes four levels of appeal:[14]

1. **Reconsideration.** A complete review of your claim by someone who did not take part in the first decision. For a disability decision, it goes back to your state's DDS. They look at all the evidence, plus any new evidence you send.
2. **Hearing before an administrative law judge (ALJ).** A judge who did not take part in the earlier decisions looks at all the evidence in your case. The hearing office will send you a notice once your hearing is scheduled.
3. **Review by the Appeals Council.** If you disagree with the judge's decision, you can ask the Appeals Council to review it. The Council may deny or dismiss your request, decide the case itself, or send it back to a judge.

4. **Federal court.** If you disagree with the Appeals Council, or it won't review your case, you can file a civil action in federal district court.

You may not have to go through every level. You start with reconsideration and keep going only if you still disagree.[15]

> **IMPORTANT: You generally have 60 days to appeal.** Social Security says you generally have 60 days from the date you receive the notice of its decision to ask for any appeal. It assumes you got the notice 5 days after the date on the letter, unless you can show it came later. If you miss the deadline, you may lose your right to appeal, and the last decision becomes final.[14]

A few more details from Social Security:[14]

- If the last day to appeal falls on a Saturday, Sunday, or national holiday, the deadline moves to the next workday.
- If you have a good reason for being late, Social Security may give you more time, but you must ask in writing and explain the reason.
- You can request reconsideration, a hearing, and Appeals Council review online at ssa.gov/apply/appeal-decision-we-made. You can also get the forms at ssa.gov/forms or call 1-800-772-1213.

- You can check the status of your appeal in your *my Social Security* account.

A new application or an appeal?

If you're denied, it can be tempting to just apply again. Be careful. The online adult disability application isn't for people who were denied disability benefits in the last 60 days; Social Security points recently denied applicants to its online appeal instead.[11] If you aren't sure which to do, ask a free legal aid office or a representative (Chapter 7) before the 60 days run out.

If your benefits are being stopped

If you already get benefits and Social Security decides you no longer have a disability, there are special rules. If you appeal within 10 days after you receive the letter, your payments will continue while Social Security decides your appeal.[14] Ask Social Security or a legal aid office what could happen if you lose the appeal, so there are no surprises.

What to do the day a denial arrives

1. **Write down the deadline.** Count 60 days from the day you got the letter, and aim to file well before then.
2. **Read the reason for the denial.** It tells you what evidence to add.

3. **File the appeal** online, by phone, or at your local office. Keep proof that you filed.
4. **Send new evidence:** new records, test results, and statements about your limits.
5. **Consider getting help** (Chapter 7), especially before a hearing.

CHAPTER 7

Getting Help: Representatives, Fees, and Free Help

You can handle your own claim or appeal. Social Security will work with you directly, and its help is free.[10] But many people find it easier with someone in their corner.

Representatives

You have the right to choose a lawyer or other qualified person to represent you. Your representative can act for you in most Social Security matters and will receive a copy of any decision. You tell Social Security in writing, usually with Form SSA-1696.[14]

About fees: Your representative cannot charge or collect a fee from you without first getting written approval from Social Security.[14] Social Security says many representatives charge a fee, but others provide free services if you're eligible, or charge only if you're awarded benefits.[14]

Under the most common setup, called a **fee agreement**, the fee can't be more than **25 percent of your past-due**

benefits or $9,200, whichever is less, for favorable decisions issued on or after November 30, 2024.[16] Past-due benefits are the back pay owed from before your approval.

Free help

- **Legal aid.** Legal aid offices give free civil legal help to people with low incomes. The Legal Services Corporation funds legal aid organizations in every state and has a search tool at lsc.gov to find one near you.[28]
- **Protection and Advocacy (P&A) agencies.** Every state and territory has a P&A or Client Assistance Program. The National Disability Rights Network lists them all. They help with problems such as Social Security or other benefits being stopped, questions about what will happen to your benefits if you go to work, and problems getting help from vocational rehabilitation.[27]
- **Work Incentives Planning and Assistance (WIPA).** Free, individualized counseling about how work affects your benefits (Chapter 10).[21]
- **Social Security itself.** Call 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778). Social Security offers free interpreter services.[1]

A warning about “help” that costs money up front

Social Security reminds people that its services are free, and that no government agency or reputable company will ask for advance fees by wire transfer or gift cards.[5] Be wary of anyone who wants money before they do anything, guarantees you’ll be approved, or asks for your *my Social Security* password. A real representative’s fee must be approved by Social Security first.[14]

What to do

1. If you’re facing a hearing, strongly consider getting a representative or free legal help.
2. Before you sign anything, ask: “How is your fee figured, and will Social Security approve it?”
3. Never give anyone your *my Social Security* password.

CHAPTER 8

Working While You Get SSDI

Many people want to try working again, part time or full time. The fear is understandable: “If I work, will I lose everything?” Social Security has special rules, called **work incentives**, so you can test your ability to work without losing your benefits all at once.[1]

> **IMPORTANT: Tell Social Security before or as soon as you start working.** Social Security says you must tell it right away if you start or return to work, and that if you don’t report earnings and get paid too much, you may have to repay it.[5]

Step 1: The Trial Work Period (TWP)

The Trial Work Period lets you test your ability to work for at least 9 months while still getting your full SSDI benefit, no matter how high your earnings are, as long as you report your work and still have a disabling condition.[17]

- **What counts as a trial work month:** In 2026, any month your gross earnings are over **$1,210**. (In 2027,

it's over $1,270.) For self-employment, a month also counts if you work more than 80 hours.[17,7]

- **How long it lasts:** 9 months, which don't have to be in a row, within a rolling 60-month (5-year) period.[17,7]
- **SSI:** The Trial Work Period does not apply to SSI.[7]

Example (made up): Dana gets SSDI. In March 2026 she earns $1,300 at a part-time job. That's over $1,210, so March counts as one of her 9 trial work months. In April she earns $900, so April doesn't count. She keeps her full SSDI check in both months, because she reported her work.

Step 2: The Extended Period of Eligibility (EPE)

After your 9th trial work month, the **Extended Period of Eligibility** begins. Its first 36 months are a safety net:[17]

- You get benefits for any month your earnings are below the SGA level ($1,690 in 2026 for non-blind people), as long as you still have a disabling condition.
- For months you earn above SGA, your cash benefit is suspended. If your earnings drop below SGA during the 36 months, your benefits can start again without a new application.
- The first time you work above SGA after the Trial Work Period, Social Security decides your disability "ceased," but it pays for that month and the next two months. This is called the **grace period**.

Step 3: Expedited Reinstatement

If your benefits end because of work, and then you have to stop or cut back because of the same or a related condition, you may be able to ask Social Security to restart your benefits without a brand-new application. You must make the request within **5 years** of when your benefits ended.[17]

What happens to Medicare

This is good news for many people. Most working people with disabilities keep Medicare for **at least 93 consecutive months** (7 years and 9 months) after the Trial Work Period ends, as long as they still have a disabling condition. Part A stays premium-free during that time.[17] After that, you may be able to buy Medicare coverage.[17]

What to do before you start a job

1. **Talk to a WIPA benefits counselor** (Chapter 10). It's free.
2. **Report your work** to Social Security. You can report wages through your *my Social Security* account or by phone.[1]
3. **Keep every pay stub** and the receipt Social Security gives you when you report.[5]
4. **Track your trial work months** on a calendar.

CHAPTER 9

Working While You Get SSI

SSI has different work rules. There's no Trial Work Period. Instead, your SSI payment goes down gradually as you earn more. Because Social Security counts less than half of your earnings, working generally leaves you with more total income.[18]

How SSI counts your earnings

Social Security doesn't count the first $65 of your monthly earnings, plus half of what's left. It also applies a $20 "general income exclusion," usually to unearned income first.[18]

Example (made up, using the 2026 federal maximum): Jordan gets SSI, has no other income, and earns $500 a month at a job.

- $500 earnings
- minus $20 general exclusion (because Jordan has no unearned income) = $480
- minus $65 earned income exclusion = $415
- minus half of what's left ($207.50) = **$207.50 countable income**

- $994 maximum minus $207.50 = about **$786.50 in SSI**

Jordan's total monthly income is now about $1,286.50 ($500 in pay plus about $786.50 in SSI), compared with $994 from SSI alone. Real calculations can differ because of state supplements, other income, and living arrangements, so ask Social Security or a benefits counselor for your own numbers. The method shown follows Social Security's Red Book examples.[18]

Other SSI work supports

- **Section 1619(a):** You may keep getting SSI cash payments even when your earnings reach the SGA level, if you were eligible for SSI for at least one month before you started working at that level and still meet the other rules.[18]
- **Section 1619(b), keeping Medicaid:** Your Medicaid can continue after your earnings get too high for an SSI payment, if you still have a disability, still meet the other rules (including the resource limit), need Medicaid to work, and earn less than your state's "threshold amount."[18]
- **Student Earned Income Exclusion:** If you're under 22 and regularly attending school, Social Security can exclude up to $2,410 a month of your earnings in 2026, up to $9,730 for the year.[18,4]
- **Work expenses:** Social Security doesn't count wages you use to pay for items or services that help you

work because of your disability, like a wheelchair, and it doesn't count certain work expenses for people who are blind.[10]

- **Restarting SSI:** If your SSI and Medicaid ended because of earnings and you stop working within 5 years, you may be able to restart them under Expedited Reinstatement.[18]

Reporting is a must

SSI is paid month by month, so changes matter. You must report changes in your income, resources, living situation, household, and more, no later than the 10th day of the month after the change happens.[19] When you work, Social Security says you must also tell it each month if your earnings change.[5]

What to do

1. Report your wages every month, and keep pay stubs.
2. Watch your bank balance so countable resources stay under $2,000 ($3,000 for a couple).[9]
3. Ask a WIPA counselor to run your numbers before you accept a raise or more hours.

CHAPTER 10

Ticket to Work and Other Supports

Ticket to Work

Ticket to Work is a free and voluntary Social Security program for people ages 18 through 64 who are blind or have a disability and get SSDI or SSI.[20] You don't need a paper ticket. You sign up with an approved service provider of your choice:[20]

- an **Employment Network (EN)**, a private organization or public agency that offers job services, or
- your **State Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) agency**, which can help people who need more significant services to make work possible.

Services can include training, career counseling, vocational rehabilitation, job placement, and ongoing support.[20] You can talk with as many Employment Networks as you like before choosing one, and you can switch later.[20]

One important protection: while you're using your Ticket and making the expected progress toward your work or education goals, Social Security won't do a medical **Continuing Disability Review** (a check on whether you still have a disability).[20,17]

How to start: Call the Ticket to Work Help Line at **1-866-968-7842** (TTY 1-866-833-2967), or visit choosework.ssa.gov.[21,5] Social Security also holds free monthly online seminars about the Ticket program and work incentives, called WISE webinars.[20]

WIPA: free benefits counseling

Social Security funds **Work Incentives Planning and Assistance (WIPA)** programs that serve the whole country and U.S. territories. WIPA counselors serve people who are already working or about to start work. They give individualized information about how work will affect your benefits and health insurance, and they verify the benefits you get so the advice fits you.[21]

To get connected, call the Ticket to Work Help Line at 1-866-968-7842 (TTY 1-866-833-2967), Monday through Friday, 8 a.m. to 8 p.m. Eastern, or use the Find Help tool at choosework.ssa.gov.[21]

ABLE accounts

An **ABLE account** (Achieving a Better Life Experience) is a tax-advantaged savings account for a person with a

disability. Family and friends can contribute too.[1] Starting January 1, 2026, people whose disability began before age 46 can qualify. Before that, the cutoff was age 26.[1] Up to $100,000 in an ABLE account does not count as a resource under SSI rules, and the money can be used for qualified disability expenses such as education, housing, transportation, job training, and assistive technology.[1] Social Security doesn't decide ABLE eligibility and doesn't endorse any ABLE provider.[1]

What to do

1. Call the Ticket to Work Help Line and ask for a WIPA referral **before** you start working.
2. Contact your State VR agency if you need training or job help.
3. If you get SSI and want to save, ask about an ABLE account.

CHAPTER 11

Your Rights at Work: ADA Accommodations

The **Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA)** is a federal civil rights law. Title I of the ADA covers jobs.

Who is covered

Title I applies to employers with **15 or more employees**. It prohibits disability discrimination in recruiting, hiring, promotions, training, pay, social activities, and other parts of employment. It limits the questions an employer can ask about your disability before a job offer, and it requires employers to make reasonable accommodations for qualified people with disabilities, unless doing so would cause undue hardship.[22]

Under the ADA, you have a disability if you have a physical or mental impairment that substantially limits a major life activity, such as hearing, seeing, speaking, thinking, walking, breathing, or doing manual tasks. To be protected at work, you must also be able to do the job, with or without a reasonable accommodation.[23]

What a reasonable accommodation is

The Justice Department describes a reasonable accommodation as "any change or adjustment to a job, the work environment, or the way things usually are done" that lets you apply for a job, do the job, or have equal access to workplace benefits.[23] Common examples include:[23,24]

- physical changes, like a ramp or a modified workspace
- sign language interpreters or readers
- a quieter workspace
- materials in accessible formats, like braille or large print
- accessible computer hardware and software
- a modified or part-time schedule
- time off for treatment
- reassignment to a vacant position

How to ask

You don't need special forms or legal words. The Justice Department says you "simply must let your employer know that you need an adjustment or change because of your disability."[23] The Equal Employment Opportunity Commission (EEOC) says requests don't have to be in writing, you don't have to mention the ADA, and a family

member, friend, or health professional can ask on your behalf.[24]

Even so, it's smart to follow up in writing so you have a record.

Step by step:

1. **Describe the problem.** Say what part of the job is hard because of your condition.
2. **Suggest a fix if you have one.** You don't have to know the perfect answer.
3. **Expect a conversation.** The employer should work with you to find an accommodation. If your disability isn't obvious, it may ask for reasonable documentation about your disability and why you need the accommodation, but in most cases it can't demand your complete medical records.[24,23]
4. **Know the employer can choose among options.** If more than one accommodation would work, the employer can choose, but what it offers must actually be effective.[24]
5. **Watch for delays.** The EEOC says an employer should respond quickly, and that unnecessary delays can violate the ADA.[24]

Free help with ideas

The **Job Accommodation Network (JAN)** offers free, expert, and confidential guidance on workplace accommodations at askjan.org or (800) 526-7234.[26]

If you think your rights were violated

Contact the EEOC at 1-800-669-4000 (TTY 1-800-669-6820). Filing a charge costs nothing, and you don't need a lawyer.[23]

> **IMPORTANT: Deadlines are short.** In general, you must file a charge with the EEOC within 180 calendar days of the discrimination. That becomes 300 days if a state or local agency enforces a law against the same kind of discrimination. Federal employees and job applicants have a different process and generally must contact an agency EEO counselor within 45 days.[25]

What to do

1. Put your accommodation request in an email or letter, even if you asked out loud first.
2. Keep copies of all replies.
3. Call JAN for ideas, and call the EEOC quickly if you're refused or punished for asking.

CHAPTER 12

Keeping Your Benefits Safe

Getting approved is a big step. Keeping your benefits running smoothly takes a few habits.

Report changes

- **SSDI:** Tell Social Security right away if you start or stop working, or if your job duties, hours, or pay change. Also report changes to any workers' compensation or other public disability benefits.[1,5]
- **SSI:** Report changes in income, bank balances, the value of things you own, where you live, who lives with you, marriage, hospital or nursing home stays, and trips out of the country of a month or more. Report them no later than the 10th day of the month after they happen.[19]

Social Security can also get your wage information directly from payroll companies if you give permission, using Form SSA-8240, so you may not need to report wages every month.[1]

Watch out for scams

Scammers know that people on disability depend on their payments. Social Security says its services are free, and that no government agency or reputable company will ask for your personal information or for advance fees by wire transfer or gift cards.[5]

If you suspect Social Security fraud, report it to the Social Security Office of the Inspector General at oig.ssa.gov/report or 1-800-269-0271 (TTY 1-866-501-2101).[5]

The companion guides in this series, *Protect Your Parents* and *After a Scam*, explain government-impostor scams and what to do if you've already been tricked.

Use your *my Social Security* account

Your account lets you check your work record, see your benefit letters, report wages, and check the status of an appeal.[1,14] Protect it like a bank account: use a strong password, turn on any extra sign-in protection, and never share your login.

What to do

1. Put a monthly reminder on your calendar: "Report changes to Social Security."
2. Keep a folder with every letter from Social Security, in date order.

3. Hang up on anyone who calls asking you to pay to "protect" your benefits. Call Social Security yourself at 1-800-772-1213.

APPENDIX

The One-Page Disability Benefits Checklist

Print this page. Free to copy and share. Amounts are for 2026; verify at ssa.gov.

REMEMBER: Rules and amounts change. Verify at ssa.gov or call 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778).

Before you apply

- ☐ Create a *my Social Security* account (ssa.gov/myaccount)
- ☐ List every doctor, clinic, and hospital, with dates
- ☐ List your medicines and tests
- ☐ List up to 5 jobs from the last 5 years
- ☐ Gather your W-2 or tax return and birth certificate
- ☐ Apply anyway, even if something's missing

Key 2026 numbers: SGA $1,690/month ($2,830 blind) · Trial work month: over $1,210 · SSI up to $994 single / $1,491 couple · SSI resource limit $2,000 / $3,000

If you're denied

- ☐ Write the deadline down: 60 days (plus 5 for mail)
- ☐ Read the reason for the denial
- ☐ File the appeal online, by phone, or at an office
- ☐ Send new medical evidence
- ☐ Call legal aid or a representative

Appeal levels: Reconsideration → Hearing (judge) → Appeals Council → Federal court

Going to work

- ☐ Call the Ticket to Work Help Line: **1-866-968-7842**
- ☐ Ask for a free WIPA benefits counselor
- ☐ Report work to Social Security, and keep pay stubs

At work: Ask for an accommodation in plain words, then confirm in writing. Ideas: **JAN (800) 526-7234**. Problems: **EEOC 1-800-669-4000** (generally 180 or 300 days to file).

Never pay up-front fees by gift card or wire, or share your password. Report fraud: **1-800-269-0271**.

From Disability Benefits Made Simple *by D.A. Williams. Sources are in the book's Notes. Not legal advice.*

RESOURCES

Where to Get Help

All of these were checked in October 2026. Phone numbers and websites can change. Look up any organization's official website yourself.

This book is not legal advice. For legal help, contact a lawyer or your local legal aid office.

Social Security

- **Social Security:** ssa.gov · 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778), Monday–Friday, 8 a.m.–7 p.m.[1]
- **Apply for disability online:** ssa.gov/applyfordisability.[11]
- **Appeal online:** ssa.gov/apply/appeal-decision-we-made.[15]
- **The Red Book** (Social Security's guide to work incentives): ssa.gov/redbook.[17]
- **Report Social Security fraud:** oig.ssa.gov/report · 1-800-269-0271 (TTY 1-866-501-2101).[5]

Work and benefits counseling

- **Ticket to Work Help Line and WIPA referrals:** 1-866-968-7842 (TTY 1-866-833-2967) · choosework.ssa.gov.[21]

Free legal and advocacy help

- **Legal aid near you:** lsc.gov (search “get legal help”).[28]
- **Protection & Advocacy agencies:** ndrn.org (find your state’s P&A or Client Assistance Program).[27]

Rights at work and in public

- **Job Accommodation Network (JAN):** askjan.org · (800) 526-7234.[26]
- **EEOC:** eeoc.gov · 1-800-669-4000 (TTY 1-800-669-6820).[25]
- **ADA Information Line:** ada.gov · 800-514-0301 (TTY 1-833-610-1264).[22]
- **ADA National Network:** adata.org · (800) 949-4232.[22]

Health coverage

- **Medicare:** 1-800-MEDICARE (1-800-633-4227), TTY 1-877-486-2048.[3]

Companion guides in this series

Protect Your Parents, *After a Scam*, *Is That Really Their Voice?*, *Apps That Actually Help*, *Stop Before You Pay*, *When Banks Cheat You*, *Naked Short Selling*, and *Don't Get Doxxed*, all by D.A. Williams and free to share.

Notes

Web addresses were checked in October 2026. Dollar amounts are the official Social Security figures for the year stated. Rules and amounts change, usually every January; always confirm current figures at ssa.gov.

1. Social Security Administration, *Disability Benefits*, Publication No. 05-10029, July 2026 (1-in-4 chance; strict definition of disability; work tests and table; how to apply and phone hours; six to eight months average processing; SSA-3368 and SSA-827; Disability Determination Services; consultative exams; five-step process; "Your doctors don't decide"; five-month waiting period; Medicare after two years, no wait for ALS and ESRD; family benefits; reporting work and Form SSA-8240; ABLE accounts, onset before age 46 effective January 1, 2026, $100,000 SSI exclusion; free interpreter services). https://www.ssa.gov/pubs/EN-05-10029.pdf
2. Social Security Administration, "Who can get Disability," accessed October 2026 (2026 SGA $1,690, or $2,830 if blind; generally 5 of the last 10 years of work; under 24 may need less; check in your account under "More Benefits"). https://www.ssa.gov/disability/eligibility
3. Social Security Administration, "Approval Process," Disability Benefits, accessed October 2026 (five full calendar months waiting period; ALS exception for approvals on or after July 23, 2020; benefit based on lifetime average earnings; automatic Medicare after 2 years of disability benefits; Medicare phone numbers). https://www.ssa.gov/benefits/disability/approval.html
4. Social Security Administration, "2026 Cost-of-Living Adjustment (COLA) Fact Sheet" (2.8 percent COLA for 2026; SGA $1,690 non-

blind and $2,830 blind; Trial Work Period $1,210; SSI federal payment standard $994 individual and $1,491 couple; SSI resource limits $2,000 and $3,000; SSI student exclusion $2,410 monthly and $9,730 annually; estimated average disabled-worker benefit $1,630 after the COLA). https://www.ssa.gov/news/en/cola/factsheets/2026.html

5. Social Security Administration, "Cost-of-Living Adjustment (COLA) Information for 2027," accessed October 2026 (3.6 percent COLA for 2027; increased SSI payments begin December 31, 2026; Ticket to Work Help Line 1-866-968-7842, TTY 1-866-833-2967; must report starting work and, for SSI, monthly earnings changes; receipts for reported earnings; services are free and no agency will request advance fees by wire transfer or gift cards; OIG Fraud Hotline 1-800-269-0271, TTY 1-866-501-2101). https://www.ssa.gov/cola/
6. Social Security Administration, Office of the Chief Actuary, "Substantial Gainful Activity," accessed October 2026 (2027 SGA $2,950 blind and $1,770 non-blind; 2026 $2,830 and $1,690; SGA earnings are net of impairment-related work expenses; SGA for the blind does not apply to SSI). https://www.ssa.gov/oact/cola/sga.html
7. Social Security Administration, Office of the Chief Actuary, "Trial Work Period," accessed October 2026 (9 months, not necessarily consecutive, in a rolling 60-month period; $1,210 in 2026 and $1,270 in 2027; does not apply to SSI). https://www.ssa.gov/oact/cola/twp.html
8. Social Security Administration, Office of the Chief Actuary, "SSI Federal Payment Amounts for 2027," accessed October 2026 ($1,029 individual and $1,544 couple for 2027; reduced by countable income; some states supplement). https://www.ssa.gov/oact/cola/SSI.html
9. Social Security Administration, "Who can get SSI," accessed October 2026 (generally for individuals who don't earn more than $2,073 from work each month; resources no more than

$2,000 individual or $3,000 couple; $1,690 work earnings test for disability applicants). https://www.ssa.gov/ssi/eligibility

10. Social Security Administration, *Supplemental Security Income (SSI)*, Publication No. 05-11000, April 2026 (who qualifies; paid from general funds; income exclusions of $20 and $65 plus half; resources not counted; where you must live; must apply for other benefits; applying online for both SSI and SSDI; Medicaid; work expense rules; may get Social Security and SSI; free help from SSA). https://www.ssa.gov/pubs/EN-05-11000.pdf
11. Social Security Administration, "Apply Online for Disability Benefits," accessed October 2026 (who can apply online; information and documents to gather; photocopies and originals; mailing cautions; "Do not delay applying"; other ways to apply; what happens after you apply; benefits on another person's record). https://www.ssa.gov/applyfordisability/index.htm
12. Social Security Administration, "Compassionate Allowances," accessed October 2026. https://www.ssa.gov/compassionateallowances/
13. Code of Federal Regulations, 20 C.F.R. § 416.918, "If you do not appear at a consultative examination," as published by the Social Security Administration (the parallel SSDI rule is 20 C.F.R. § 404.1518). https://www.ssa.gov/OP_Home/cfr20/416/416-0918.htm
14. Social Security Administration, *Your Right to Question the Decision Made on Your Claim*, Publication No. 05-10058, March 2026 (four levels of appeal; 60 days plus 5-day mailing presumption; weekend and holiday rule; good-cause extensions; online appeals; payment continuation if a cessation is appealed within 10 days; right to representation; fees need SSA approval; Form SSA-1696; checking appeal status). https://www.ssa.gov/pubs/EN-05-10058.pdf
15. Social Security Administration, "Appeal a decision we made," accessed October 2026. https://www.ssa.gov/apply/appeal-decision-we-made

16. Social Security Administration, “Fee Agreements,” Representing SSA Claimants, accessed October 2026 (lesser of 25 percent of past-due benefits or $9,200 for favorable decisions on or after November 30, 2024). https://www.ssa.gov/representation/fee_agreements.htm
17. Social Security Administration, *The Red Book*, “SSDI Only Employment Supports,” accessed October 2026 (Trial Work Period, $1,210 in 2026, 80 hours of self-employment; Extended Period of Eligibility and 36-month re-entitlement period; grace period; Expedited Reinstatement within 5 years; extended Medicare for at least 93 months; no continuing disability review while actively using a Ticket). https://www.ssa.gov/redbook/eng/ssdi-only-employment-supports.htm
18. Social Security Administration, *The Red Book*, “SSI Only Employment Supports,” accessed October 2026 (earned income exclusion of $65 plus one-half; $20 general income exclusion; Student Earned Income Exclusion, $2,410 a month and $9,730 a year in 2026; Section 1619(a) and 1619(b); Expedited Reinstatement). https://www.ssa.gov/redbook/eng/ssi-only-employment-supports.htm
19. Social Security Administration, “Report changes to your situation,” Supplemental Security Income, accessed October 2026. https://www.ssa.gov/ssi/reporting/changes
20. Social Security Administration, “Ticket Overview,” The Work Site, accessed October 2026. https://www.ssa.gov/work/overview.html
21. Social Security Administration, “Work Incentives Planning and Assistance,” The Work Site, accessed October 2026. https://www.ssa.gov/work/WIPA.html
22. U.S. Department of Justice, Civil Rights Division, “Guide to Disability Rights Laws,” ADA.gov, last updated February 28, 2020 (Title I covers employers with 15 or more employees; ADA Information Line; ADA National Network). https://www.ada.gov/resources/disability-rights-guide/

23. U.S. Department of Justice, Civil Rights Division, “A Guide for People with Disabilities Seeking Employment,” ADA.gov, last updated February 25, 2020. https://www.ada.gov/resources/employment-seeking-guide/

24. U.S. Equal Employment Opportunity Commission, “Enforcement Guidance on Reasonable Accommodation and Undue Hardship under the ADA,” October 17, 2002 (requests in plain English, not required in writing, may come from a family member or health professional; reasonable documentation; employer may choose among effective accommodations; respond expeditiously). https://www.eeoc.gov/laws/guidance/enforcement-guidance-reasonable-accommodation-and-undue-hardship-under-ada

25. U.S. Equal Employment Opportunity Commission, “Time Limits For Filing A Charge,” accessed October 2026. https://www.eeoc.gov/time-limits-filing-charge

26. Job Accommodation Network, askjan.org, accessed October 2026. https://askjan.org/

27. National Disability Rights Network, “NDRN Member Agencies – P&A – CAP,” accessed October 2026. https://www.ndrn.org/about/ndrn-member-agencies/

28. Legal Services Corporation, “I Need Legal Help,” accessed October 2026. https://www.lsc.gov/about-lsc/what-legal-aid/get-legal-help